

Vietnamese Language in Bilingual and Multilingual Environments: Acquisition, Learning and Unlearning



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Abstract Bilingualism and second language learning always involve the interaction between two language systems or subsystems. When young children acquire language, often there is more than one. Considering the modern era, as the Vietnamese language has expanded geographically and culturally, coming into contact with other language communities, all of the different combinations of acquisition, learning and unlearning have come into play. These include, today, perhaps for the first time in recent history, language interactions that include first language attrition. This progress report of tentative results from our project compares the bilingual learning circumstances in two studies (in Taiwan and in northern Vietnam) where one language is in ascendance and the other may not be. The other language may be not developing at the same rate of progress or it may be undergoing replacement by the dominant language. In the larger project that encompasses the two studies, the Vietnamese language is part of the unfolding outcome of learning and attrition. On the other hand, it could become part of the process of potential recovery and stabilization of the minority language in some cases.

Keywords Bilingual communities · Language attrition · Language assessment · Bilingual speech · Thái language

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1 Introduction

Languages that are spoken around the world come into bilingual contact of different kinds—often the contact is multilingual. These contact situations involve learning, on the one hand, and situations that involve attrition, what in the title of this study is called “unlearning.” In all complex and large-scale bilingual contact scenarios, both processes unfold as normal outcomes of language development. Learning a language does not necessarily imply attrition of another; but attrition, when it is of the first language, does imply learning of another.¹ In this regard, bilingualism that includes the Vietnamese language is no longer an exception, if perhaps in the past it might have been because there were few large overseas communities (that became bilingual) and due to the isolation (from the national language) of minority language speech communities in Vietnam mainly along the borderland regions. The distinctive sociocultural contexts of Vietnam and Taiwan offer valuable opportunities for studying this kind of language contact. In Vietnam, minority groups like the Thái have historically faced linguistic isolation, limiting bilingualism. Recent socio-economic changes, however, have significantly altered the previous scenario of relative stability. In Taiwan, Vietnamese immigrants and their children face the challenge of preserving the home language as second language learning of Mandarin, for the entire family, becomes a priority; see (Yeh et al., 2014).

Among bilingual and second language learners of Vietnamese, the following categories can be studied, covering most examples of our topic:

1. Early child bilinguals: child acquisition of two languages, i.e., simultaneous bilingual development, Vietnamese and another language. Both languages are first (L1) languages—known as 2L1 (De Houwer, 2022).
2. Early L2 learning of Vietnamese by children who speak another language as L1. In this category, Vietnamese would be a family or community language. In (1) it must, typically, be a family language.
3. Late L2 learning of Vietnamese by adolescents and young adults.

¹Regarding the idea that L1 attrition is linked to the learning of another language is based on the observation from research that erosion of language competence in one language without replacing development from another only occurs in situations of trauma, brain damage or other kind of impairment that affects the neural circuits of the Faculty of Language, what we call a language disability. Of course, a localized *trauma to the brain* can also selectively affect only one of the subsystems of language (Paradis, 2008). At the speech community level, note that the corollary holds true in all cases; there is no known exception: L1 attrition only emerges in community contexts of bilingualism; language maintenance is assured in contexts of separation/seclusion and monolingualism. Related to these concepts, in the field of language development studies, the distinction is often made between *acquisition* (unconscious and spontaneous development, typically associated with one’s mother-tongue during the preschool years) and *learning* (a process that involves a much greater degree of awareness, is more deliberate, and often more cognitively demanding).

4. Students in a foreign language (FL) learning, classroom-type, setting. This category of language learner often comes together in the same language classroom with learners in (2) and (3) above.²

Within the categories of (1)–(3), we will consider the specific conditions that lead to the onset of attrition. In this study, as mentioned above, the focus of attention will be mainly on *first* language attrition. Schmitt and Sorokina (2024) and De Houwer (2022) present an overview of the recent findings in the field. Category (4) can be considered separately, as an opportunity for language recovery or revitalization, as is the case in FL learning programs in Taiwan.

- The two studies of our project, in its exploratory stage, have focused on:
- Language learning among child bilingual speakers (the national language and a minority language) in Vietnam, and separately
 - The experience of immigrants to Taiwan and their first-generation children.

The two studies (see Table 1) consider the language development situations of (1) (2) (3) and (4). Despite the important differences, they all share certain acquisition and learning circumstances. One that they have in common is how language learning is related to literacy learning in academic settings.

The overarching research question of the project, in the two studies, in Vietnam and Taiwan, follows from the accepted understanding in the field of bilingual studies that the relationship between the two languages of the bilingual speaker can be described as changing over time, often in unexpected ways (Meisel, 2021). The focus of this report is about a change dynamic that is an example of imbalance or instability. First language attrition at first seems to be an exceptional scenario of bilingualism because there are other cases of imbalance that appear less eventful or disruptive. An example of a relatively uneventful and harmonious imbalance would

Table 1 Comparison between the Taiwan and Vietnam studies

Taiwan	Vietnam
Immigrant adults and their adult children	Child learners
Visits to home country	Language contact is local
L2 learning of Chinese	L2 learning (historically) of Vietnamese
Moderate variation in L2 learning	Uniform ultimate attainment of L2
L1 & L2—significant linguistic parallels	L1 & L2—Significant linguistic parallels
Wide variation in L2 literacy (adults)	Uniform ultimate attainment of L2 literacy (adults)
L2 writing system—morphosyllabic	L2 writing system—alphabetic
Attrition of Vietnamese language	Possible attrition of Thái language (unconfirmed)

²In formal classroom instruction, as in the higher grades and in university, students make use of both second language *learning* and second language *acquisition* processes. In this case we can define “learning” as more deliberate, focused on language forms to a greater degree, and “acquisition” as implicit to a greater degree. But the two processes interact: for example, while paying attention to grammar patterns and word meanings learners receive useful comprehensible input.

be that between the knowledge of our first language-mother tongue³ and the knowledge of the second language that we learn later in life. However, L1 attrition is more common than most researchers probably acknowledge; and while it often appears as difficult and debilitating, it is not clear that in most cases, in fact, it is, or necessarily must be so. At the same time, we acknowledge that this suggestion is controversial. What should not be controversial is the understanding that L1 attrition, per se, is not an example of deficit or language impairment. See Notes 1 and 2 for one reason why it is not either one nor the other, except in cases of actual trauma to the language networks of the nervous system (Paradis, 2008).

The specific overarching research question of the two studies is to ask what evidence is, or could be, available for studying the kinds of imbalance that L1 attrition is an example of, so as to understand all of the different kinds better.⁴ One way to approach this question is to pay special attention to instances of instability between language-a and language-b that involve a kind of “competition.”

2 National Language and Minority Language Bilingualism

2.1 *When Vietnamese Language Learning Faced Strong Competition, in Vietnam*

For many years Vietnamese language learning, in its multilingual homeland, encountered relatively strong competitors within the upland communities along the international border with its three neighbors. That is, the autochthonous languages of each locality and region served the communicative and cognitive needs of their speakers in all or almost all domains and endeavors. This situation began to change with the first national literacy campaign following independence, and has been

³In contrast to the bilingual and L2 learners of Vietnamese in (1)–(4), as in all populations, there are the speakers that correspond to the category of L1 acquisition/learning as native speakers of Vietnamese only. Separate from the bilingual scenarios, these children are no different in their core linguistic and cognitive capabilities from the same population of monolingual L1 speakers anywhere else. As in all cases of L1 development, the emergence of their L1 must have occurred during the early years of childhood if the language developed normally (Gleitman et al., 2021; Becker & Deen, 2020). Though seemingly obvious, the theoretical implications for bilingualism are far-reaching. The mother tongue is unique, shaped by specialized language acquisition mechanisms, often referred to as the Faculty of Language (Saffran et al., 2001).

⁴More than one paper on bilingualism has borrowed the title of Sergio Leone’s 1966 epic western, “The good the bad and the ugly,” to describe the results of research [Il buono, il brutto, il cattivo] (The good, the ugly, the bad—in slightly different order from the English version). We can all agree that strictly speaking there cannot be anything “ugly” about bilingualism. In scientific work we also try to avoid the idea of the “good” and the “bad” as this dichotomy distracts us from better understanding what “is.” Especially in research on topics that have the appearance of being sensitive, as is the topic of this report, the starting point should be the objective description of conditions and events in the world.

changing at an accelerating pace ever since. Today there is competition between the national language and the minority languages, but of a different kind.

As geographical, economic, and cultural isolation break down, monolingualism in the national minority languages (fifty-three) becomes less and less sustainable. The transition at first is gradual. In the near future, none of the 53 languages will be spoken in communities that can be described as truly remote and isolated. A systematic study needs to be carried out on this point of clarification: today there may not be any remaining towns or villages in which the Vietnamese language is not spoken by a majority of adults and children (see Duong & Nguyen, 2023). The indices of cross-cultural intermarriage, (especially) female L2 learning of the national language, literacy, and elementary school attendance by girls will continue to rise. Today, the Gender Parity Index (GPI) for Vietnam hovers around 1.00 (United Nations, 2021). These indicators probably already correlate with the sale of basic girls' and women's footwear in previously remote and out-lying communities.

The same historical tendency, subject to local variation, has been observed in all regions of the world with similar multilingual composition. The historic trajectory described above is truly international. The following Fig. 1 is an example of early attempts from the previous century to reform rural education, to make it more inclusive. Similar themes related to language and literacy learning were promoted in Vietnam after independence (Ngô et al., 2024). The current study confirmed the impact of the literacy promotion of recent decades in one, Thái-speaking, community of northern Vietnam in particular. Parents, usually mothers, who came for the interview on language use at home, and to give researchers permission to work with their son or daughter on language assessment, typically volunteered to fill out the questionnaire form themselves and discussed the objectives of the study in native-like, error-free, Vietnamese, all without exception. Years ago, Baker (2001) described the general sociolinguistic phenomenon: how, over time, monolingualism



Fig. 1 From a 1920 literacy campaign poster, Latin America

is undermined by broader material forces associated with cultural and economic progress.

2.2 *Partial Results from Bilingual Communities*

The study sought to examine the current relationship between the national language and a minority language. Tentative findings on aspects of language contact in Thái-speaking communities of Thanh Hóa province, while they are provisional and require validation and confirmation, can be reported here for initial discussion. Data are available from an assessment of bilingualism (balance between Vietnamese and Thái language competence) in a sample of six-year-old first-grade students.⁵

The partial results are noteworthy given the social and linguistic profile of the community: rural economy/mountain region, in close proximity to speakers of languages of the Tai family in the Laotian provinces across the border as well as throughout the northwestern region of Thanh Hóa and neighboring provinces. The most recent census report from the locality where the assessment was carried out indicates over 99% of households self-identify as ethnically Thái. The parents ($N = 47$) of first-grade children interviewed confirmed that all forty-seven children know both Vietnamese and Thái.

In addition, local educators described the language learning approach adopted by families and by the preschool program (2 years pre-K, 1 year kindergarten, called *lớp lớn*): a broadly-based and consistent language socialization, beginning prior to pre-K, to emphasize exposure to and use of the Vietnamese language. Parenthetically, the study was able to confirm from parent interviews that the effort was feasible and successful: as mentioned above, all (mainly) mothers and grandmothers were fully literate and possessed fluent command of Vietnamese, a result of the (two to three) generational succession of national language and literacy campaigns following independence. Phan (2024) and Ngô et al. (2024) provide detailed accounts of national language education policies aimed at promoting Vietnamese literacy and the widespread adoption of *chữ quốc ngữ*.

Given this background data, the average score attained on the Vietnamese-language subtest by the 6-year-old first-grade students was not completely unexpected: 31.9 out of 32 points.⁶ However, the results were noteworthy: the children had successfully replicated the L2 learning patterns of their parents and

⁵Pending first-level standardization and report of final field testing, the *Bilingual Assessment of Child Language (Vietnamese-Thái version)*, *Đánh giá song ngữ ngôn ngữ trẻ em (bản Việt-Thái)* was administered in 2024 to a pilot sample ($N = 47$) in preparation for a large-scale study of bilingual development.

⁶Recall that the assessment instrument tested for basic linguistic competence, measured by means of a conversational and context-embedded dialogue, in which a ceiling effect is expected for native speakers or highly proficient L2 speakers. See Notes 1, 2 and 3 for the research foundations for this prediction.

grandparents, particularly in acquiring Vietnamese as the national language. It is possible that many of the child participants were already 2L1 bilinguals, having mastered both languages long before pre-K.

The result that did call the study's attention was from the Thái-language subtest: 27.8 out of 32. On the one hand, the comparison does not suggest a major difference from the performance in Vietnamese. Thirty-five children (74.5%) attained a level of "native" or "near-native," and none scored within the two ranges of "beginner." Seven scored within the "advanced L2 learner" range, and 5 within the "intermediate L2 learner" range, total of 12 (25.5%).

The question is, again considering the sociolinguistic profile of the community and parents' testimony about Thái-language use at home: why isn't Thái linguistic competence within *exactly* the same range as Vietnamese? Two alternative explanations come forward from examination of the patterns of response.

1. That in fact, the community and school early emphasis on Vietnamese language learning has resulted in the emergence of a shift, barely noticeable, toward the national language and away from Thái.
2. That the difference (average 4.1 points out of 32) is mainly a reflection of a performance disparity, not one of underlying knowledge of language. Closer examination of the origin of children's responses that yielded less than full credit (1 point instead of 2) showed that all of the responses that received half-credit were for the same reason, consistent with the instruction manual: answering the examiner's question, correctly, entirely in Vietnamese instead of Thái (after being reminded: "can you say it in Thái?"). Hypothetically, not discounting the one point for Vietnamese-language response, all children except for one, would fall within the "native-speaker" range of 29—32, resulting, hypothetically, in no significant difference in performance.

Looking back on the sociolinguistic context data and other "imbalances" between the *use* of the two languages (e.g. the Thái-speaking children in dialogue with the evaluator, on the Vietnamese sub-test, never replied in Thái, and never even codeswitched to Thái, while switching to Vietnamese was prolific during the Thái-language sub-test.) a provisional conclusion seems to be appropriate: neither (1) the language-shift (competence change) hypothesis nor (2) the surface performance-only variation hypothesis can be discounted, for now, based on the available information.

The difference between hypothesis (1) and (2) is related to the distinction often made in the language sciences between *competence* and *performance*. While in some respects still controversial, the basic concept refers to the widely observed difference between the knowledge that children have acquired and their ability in all situations to demonstrate this same knowledge. This observation appears in both research and even informal observation. Another way to conceive of the distinction is to think of *competence* in terms of underlying "knowledge of language" and *performance* in terms of "ability." On the surface, informally, this concept helped to put into perspective certain aspects of fieldwork observation in the Thái-speaking village (classroom, playground and one-to-one interview).

2.3 *Two Different Scenarios of L1 Attrition*

In some ways, L1 attrition is the mirror image of acquisition. In bilingualism, as the more robustly developing language system proceeds along its course of attaining completeness, the weaker system begins to cede domains of competence in a process of replacement. The emerging stronger language, the so-called replacing language, could have been:

- the twin partner of early 2L1 development, or
- an early L2 introduced during the first years of preschool (or even earlier), kindergarten, or first grade. For the purposes of the present discussion, we will set aside the scenario of late childhood or (rarer still) adult L1 attrition.

This is the process of first language attrition, initially; but the final outcomes are very different. The difference bears directly on the main research question of this chapter. To review, the alternative cases of uneven bilingual development considered so far are:

- Minority language attrition among children learning Vietnamese as an early L2 or acquiring Vietnamese as a first language, one of the languages of their 2L1 bilingual development.
- Immigration-related attrition of L1 Vietnamese among first-generation children born, for example in Taiwan or the United States.

The language system undergoing eventual replacement faces two pathways, toward two outcomes:

- leading to an almost complete replacement in which only a memory trace remains of the previous L1, or
- toward a stabilization of competence in the weaker language similar to a kind of second language competence. The second outcome encompasses a wide range of possible new L2-type language systems, and there is nothing in principle that blocks it from advancing, with time and sustained exposure, toward successively higher levels of L2-type proficiency.

Both outcomes are associated with the category known as heritage language learner. It is possible that even a very low level of memory of an eroded language can be a beginning competence platform from which forward development can build upon (Vergara Wilson & Ibarra, 2015).

From the point of view of the language preservation planning or policy perspective, the second outcome is perhaps more interesting to consider. For space limitations, this chapter cannot address the applied (pedagogical) recommendations in any detail; see: Kao (2006). But a better understanding of the two outcomes of replacing language development, in particular the cognitive and linguistic underpinnings of the second, would clearly be highly relevant to any national or local language preservation/revitalization program.

We can return, for now, to the tentative results of the Vietnamese-Thái bilingual assessment presented in the previous section, and assume for argument's sake that the imbalance in performance between the two languages does in fact reflect a true beginning of displacement (shift) of the Thái language from a coequal counterpart of 2L1 development to the slightly weaker counterpart, with Vietnamese now as the (emerging) dominant language. Hypothetically, we are assuming that the imbalance is not simply a performance fluctuation due to a contextual-pragmatic constraint (the alternative hypothesis). Local educators and researchers might ask: given the strong ethnolinguistic loyalty and the language's demographic dominance (over 99% of speakers), what would be the material consequences of a noticeable but not significant and not continuously and irreversibly attriting of Thái? That is, the erosion of Thái does not continue toward lower and lower levels ending in a level of language ability that is no longer usable.

Vietnamese language, during the pre-K, kindergarten, and primary grades, takes "center stage"—paraphrasing from the above-cited observations of Ngô et al. (2024)—for the purpose of fully consolidating strong literacy skills in quốc ngữ. Centering Vietnamese language learning in K-5 enables children to access other subjects, as textbooks are written in the national language; Nguyễn (2022a) presents an opposing view. The authors of this chapter are not taking a side, at the present moment, in the lively and informative debate among researchers and scholars of societal multilingualism and bilingual education in Vietnam on these questions. This discussion we, in fact, recommend because it will provide clarity on important concepts of language learning. In addition to the exchange of proposals, observation of classrooms, and interviews with teachers, there is a need to take an additional starting point: fieldwork focused on learning outcomes and quantitative analysis that prioritizes direct measurement of language abilities, including progress in each language bilingual children speak and literacy-related language skills.

To reiterate the above proposed idea, the unfolding of L1 attrition can take the pathway of stabilization around an L2-like proficiency level sufficient for virtually all communicative functions. Intermediate or advanced L2-like proficiency in Thái can even serve higher-order expression and comprehension. Coincidentally, community informants of the Thái-speaking village in question offered the observation to the principal investigator that older children (e.g., in sixth grade) begin to converse more frequently in the Thái language, in comparison to younger students immersed in the strongly incentivized Vietnamese language-rich environment of preschool, K, and first grade.

3 Taiwan: Language Maintenance among First Generation Children?

The Taiwan bilingualism study provided exploratory data for proposing hypotheses for future study on the question of possible L1 attrition versus preservation of mother-tongue Vietnamese. The estimates of Vietnamese learning by first generation children appear to fall roughly within international averages from available data, for example from the United States, country of the largest concentration of overseas families (Rumbaut, 2004).

Combining the recollection of mothers regarding their Taiwanese-born children with that of first-generation young people, total $N = 34$, approximately 30% of the first generation has preserved native, near-native or intermediate L2 ability in Vietnamese. Given our sample of highly motivated university learners, mother-tongue preservation rates in the general population might be lower. An earlier estimate of first-generation children's language ability by Kao (2006) falls roughly within the same range. In the US study, 90% of third-generation young people customarily spoke only English. Note that this is a language *use* estimate, not one of actual competence (Dao & Bankston, 2010). But it does provide an estimate of a trend that is widely observed.

During interviews in Taiwan, indicators suggested a L1 preservation advantage for Taiwanese-born children exposed to *significant* Vietnamese input from their immigrant mother. These would have been cases of 2L1 development (Vietnamese and Chinese) where Vietnamese did not undergo extensive early attrition and maintained a native or strong L2-type level into the elementary grades. For some children a more frequent opportunity to visit family in Vietnam appears to be related to a combination of two kinds of motivation (instrumental and integrative), expressed, coincidentally, by a majority of the first-generation informants. Integrative motivation is about cultural and interpersonal relationships, e.g. with family; instrumental motivation is related to practical considerations, e.g. better job prospects.

Predictably, L1 maintenance by immigrants themselves, average 20 years after arrival, is 100% native-speaking (from an informal assessment that included a second cohort of immigrants, bilingual Cantonese-Vietnamese speakers—total of all informants: $N = 62$). Interestingly, information from the second cohort of Cantonese-Vietnamese bilinguals indicated a more pronounced shift toward Mandarin Chinese monolingualism by their Taiwan-born children, probably bringing the overall average of all 62 informants closer to the US average for Vietnamese-language preservation (Dao & Bankston, 2010). Studies of first generation bilingual populations in other major diaspora communities (United Kingdom and Australia) report language preservation and language recovery indices by heritage speakers within more or less the same range as in Taiwan and North America (Nguyễn, 2022b; Tran et al., 2024). The qualitative descriptions of language learning and attrition, as would be expected, mark the same tendencies.

In studies of immigration, estimating the incidence of L1 attrition in the first-generation population is notoriously difficult because available data is almost

always indirect, based on memory and self-report during an interview. Thus, we report the findings as a suggestion for future research that can apply different methods: for example, direct sampling of language ability of a large number of participants.

A large-scale study featuring direct assessment of the degree of Vietnamese language proficiency that has been preserved by young people, in Taiwan for example, could inform second language learning initiatives of various kinds. Motivated heritage language learners can avail themselves of learning materials designed for beginner level learners enrolled in university programs (Lê, 2021a) in: self-study, individual tutor instruction, and long-term study-group sessions organized and sustained by learners themselves. Audio-visual resources from the internet are more effectively exploited by groups of learners working together.

4 Language Interaction when Speaking

4.1 Coordination in Bilingual Speech

If the idea of *competition* applies to non-balanced bilingual development and L1 attrition, other kinds of interaction between language systems and subsystems in bilingual speech are largely about *cooperation* (or *coordination*). In bilingualism, there are some dynamics that are competing and others that are coordinating. Thus, a research approach of great productivity for both adults and children is the analysis of linguistic interaction in speech and in comprehension: mixing, codeswitching, borrowing, different kinds of insertion, etc. from language-a to language-b, and vice-versa (Muysken, 2000; Myers-Scotton, 1998).

In this domain, the various types of significant imbalance and tendencies of strong preference might be evidence of changes in competence. Alternatively, they may be evidence of the intervention of other factors, for example, incentives or constraints related to the social context of language use, independent of actual competence in one language or the other. Recall that we considered these two alternatives when discussing how to score, and how to interpret, children's opposite-language response during the Thái-language subtest (the Chicken Story) of the bilingual assessment.

4.2 Switching from One Sentence to another

When languages come into contact outside of each other's sentences, keeping the sentences "internally unilingual," the grammars of language-a and language-b don't interact directly (this kind of switching or mixing is called inter-sentential). How should we understand this kind of language interaction, and what conclusions might

we be able to draw from analyzing different kinds of patterns? The question is relevant to the overarching research question of the study. As was just suggested above, can contrasting patterns of mixing/switching of the inter-sentential kind be taken as evidence for the emergence of one bilingual learning-unlearning outcome or another? Is a given imbalance or pronounced tendency, especially if all indices point “in the same direction,” suggestive of a divergence in development: toward the consolidation of a dominant language system and the concomitant weakening of the other? Myers-Scotton (1998) presents one point of view directly related to the research problem of L1 attrition. The examples from her study are of the intra-sentential type of switching, the topic of the next section, but are still relevant to our question.

We can now revisit the interesting cases of opposite-language responses in the Thái-Vietnamese language assessment. In the results, a visible pattern emerged that was immediately apparent. When the children engaged in dialogue around the story illustrations during the Thái subtest, different types of switching appeared in most of the Q&A responses. On the free narration section in which children were given the opportunity to tell the story independently, a large majority of retellings, 40 out of 47, either contained a switch or insertion of some kind (30) or were retold completely in Vietnamese (10).

In contrast, the *same bilingual children* during the Vietnamese subtest, never codeswitched, borrowed, inserted a word from Thái, or answered a Vietnamese-language question in Thái during the Q&A, nor told their independent version of the story in Thái, nor inserted a Thái word or phrase; not a single instance.

This provisional summary of the retelling results will then be compared to the difference between Vietnamese and Thái in the Q&A averages (each of the 16 questions scored 0, 1, or 2): 31.9 and 27.8, respectively. Recall that the greater part of the difference of 4.1 was due entirely to giving an answer (correct for meaning) in Vietnamese to the question in Thái. It is important, one last time, to reiterate our tentative conclusion, that the difference in results between Vietnamese and Thái cannot yet be attributed to either:

- an incipient L1 attrition, or
- a sociolinguistic language use bias/preference on children's part.

Tentatively, we can consider more in detail some of the different scenarios of bilingual speech from our experience with interviewing the children from the Thái-speaking village. Recall that the Chicken Story dialogues and stories took place in a classroom, in school, a context that is associated, for everyone, as a Vietnamese-language use domain. There was no evidence that children were discouraged from speaking Thái in school; in fact playground talk of the first graders was estimated from extensive observation as 50% in Thái language. But the implicit expectation, while in class, is perhaps that one *should* speak Vietnamese. In addition, children know perfectly well that the teacher-interviewer during the Chicken Story is bilingual (because he is a neighbor in the village and works in the school). Even though he requested that the answer be given in Thái every time that an answer was given completely in Vietnamese, children knew that he would understand their repeated

answer in Vietnamese. Is it possible that there appeared a kind of “conflict of expectations” on the part of the bilingual children: what is the typical/normal choice of language in school -vs- the polite request of a teacher to repeat an answer in the other language? These are important situational factors to take into account when evaluating mixed language discourse by young bilinguals.

The next round of fieldwork and analysis will attempt to narrow the possible explanation, from two down to one. Of course, for this cohort of 47 six-year-olds, the explanation might be that some of the children in question might have indeed experienced the beginnings of L1 attrition of Thái and the others have not, their lower score explained by the second, sociolinguistic context factor. So far, the example of mixing is mainly of the inter-sentential kind, or even between an entire conversational turn and another.

4.3 *Analysis of Bilingual Sentences*

Intra-sentential mixing involves the interaction between the respective grammars, within the same sentence. When the grammars of each language come into contact in this way, the speaker will need to combine words and phrases in such a way that the sentence is understandable. Assuming that the listener also knows enough of the two languages involved, this might be the first problem that the bilingual speaker must attend to. The mixed language sentence then should, or will tend to be, “grammatical” in a special way: the constituents that come together from language-a and language-b will tend to be combined in a way that is “well-formed.” Poplack (2015) and Myers-Scotton (2006) are an introduction to this concept. This, in fact, might be the first problem that the bilingual speaker attends to—“understandable” and syntactically “well-formed” are obviously related.

Then for a given example, we can also ask the question: do the constituents from language-a and language-b combine in a way that is not “well-formed” (“conflicting” in some way). As is obvious, the complicating factor in all of these kinds of assessment is to what extent, or how “easily,” do the two languages in contact allow for grammatical patterns from one language to be integrated into the grammatical patterns of the other.

In this section, we will examine switching in two contrasting bilingual pairs, Vietnamese-English and Vietnamese-Thái. In the examples below, interesting patterns of mixed language grammar will present themselves, depending on the parallels and non-parallels between the “monolingual grammars” of each language.

Codeswitching by Vietnamese-English bilinguals is perhaps representative of one of these types—examples courtesy of Lê (2022); also see general commentary by Lê (2021b) and Nguyễn (2012).

Cô gửi đường link trong group Zalo lớp đó.

<I sent the link to that class’s Zalo group.>

Here, the speaker adjusts the word order of “Zalo group” to conform to Vietnamese syntax, so that the modifier follows the noun. It creates an

ungrammatical English noun phrase, but we have to say that no confusion of meaning results. The English constituents are inserted into a Vietnamese frame.

Mấy link sau là từng quiz cô lọc ra.

<The following links are sorted from quizzes.>

We can consider the above bilingual sentence as an example of a different kind of alteration. Note how the English words “links” and “quizzes” are modified so as to be better integrated into the grammatical pattern of the sentence: deleting the inflectional morpheme for plural (-s & -es), form that does not exist in Vietnamese. Keeping the (-s & -es) would make the sentence sound awkward, even though the insertions are English words that should carry the plural morpheme. Vietnamese grammar requires an adjustment, resulting in a syntactically well-formed sentence.

Like và share giúp con với cô.

<Help me like and share the post.>

In this case, no minor “noise,” even, of any kind occurs in the hybrid sentence. Overall, in the three examples we could say that Vietnamese comes to be the “matrix language” (Myers-Scotton, 2006), the frame. That is, the insertions, from English, are integrated into the guiding grammatical patterns of Vietnamese.

A different codeswitching scenario presents itself when the languages are Thái and Vietnamese. Examples are from the 6-year-old bilinguals of the Thanh Hóa province study.

เห็น (泰) ừ (越). บอก (泰), chị ơi 1 con gà trống.

<See a rooster. Tell sister, sister, a rooster.>

Ừ (泰) ừ (越) em trai (越) ừ (越) ừ (越), mẹ (越) ừ (越) ừ (越), em trai (越) ừ (越), em trai (越) ừ (越).
 Ừ (泰) ừ (越) cẩn thận (越), rồi em trai (越) ừ (越).

<Sister, brother go outside. Mother at home to feed chicken. Brother sees chicken. Brother runs to catch up. Sister said: “you careful”. Then brother falls down.>

Ồ (泰) chào mẹ (越) ừ (越) ừ (越) ừ (越). mẹ (越) ừ (越) 2 chị em

<Saying bye to mother, to work. Mother say bye sister brother.>

In contrast to the Vietnamese-English bilingual speech, the alternation between Vietnamese and Thái, based on initial examination of the extensive corpus, does not appear to require adjustment or modification of inserted or switched constituents. The three examples are representative of the extensive parallel of grammar between Vietnamese and Thái.

5 Contributing Factor or Barometer

The Myers-Scotton (1998) paper on switching and attrition raises the question of whether the relationship is one of cause-effect or indicator. While her argument is mainly interested in the latter, many observers of switching and mixing phenomena, in particular community language advocates, focus attention on both possibilities: cause-effect and indicator. The third alternative would be that neither is of concern to either community activists who promote minority language preservation or to linguists interested in measurement. That said, it would be difficult to sustain that in the long run aspects of language contact, revealed in performance, are not evidence of language change over time, in some way or another. Aspects of language change at the population level may also reflect, indirectly, changes in individual speakers' knowledge as they learn a second language. The key question is: which cross-language interactions, such as majority language influence, reliably indicate language replacement? For example, the acceptance of borrowed vocabulary, by itself, would not, or may not, be evidence of attrition, while the displacement of grammatical forms under the influence of the expanding and competing language might be.

On another level, in discussions of attrition, it is perhaps more accurate to describe the attrition process as "replacement" rather than "language loss." A new language subsystem, such as a L2, *replaces* the attriting subsystem, because the Faculty of Language does not allow a vacuum to persist. The capacity to acquire/learn language is not lost; rather, the competing/expanding language subsystem occupies the space of the receding language subsystem. This theoretical assumption (that should still be taken as a hypothesis) is in line with everyday experience and observation; and see Notes 1, 2 and 3 for how the relevant concepts from research apply in this case.

While the results of the assessment of bilingualism in the 6-year-old population of our study do not (yet) count as evidence for this hypothesis, they are not inconsistent with it. If we assume (which we can only do provisionally) that the performance of the 12 children who scored below near-native level in Thái in the present study is evidence of incipient L1 attrition, then according to the *replacement language hypothesis*, another language must be taking the place of the mother-tongue language. In fact, all twelve children who scored below near-native level in Thái scored 32 (100%) on the Vietnamese subtest. This last observation can only be taken as provisional and tentative because the final analysis of the data is not complete, and such a conclusion would have to be checked against findings of a follow-up study that confirms or contradicts the first results.

6 Recovery of Language Competence in the Weaker Language

Even if the above interpretation of incipient L1 attrition of Thái language can be rejected (in favor of the alternative hypothesis that ascribes the difference in performance to the impact of language use context, a sociolinguistic factor unrelated to competence), the result suggests consideration of a modest teaching reform. The following proposed adjustment to the current educational program is based on a model of bilingual development discussed extensively in a previous stage of the project of similar characteristics (Francis, 2012).

Comparing the two groups of first graders in the Vietnam study (35 native/near native and 12 “equivalent to” advanced/intermediate L2 learners), both groups possess a level of listening comprehension in Thái that is almost the same, if not exactly the same. Thus, all students in the first-grade classes would benefit from the same type of *academic-type* listening lesson: comprehension of higher-order, school-related and therefore literacy-related, discourse.

The source for these texts, in Thái language, is readily available in the oral tradition of the community, in large quantity and of high quality from the literary point of view. Local scholars work on a separate project that compiles and documents the literary works of the region, some of it in written form and some of it preserved in the oral tradition. These community efforts support research showing that integrating traditional narrative into the teaching program enhances both language learning and cultural knowledge.

Child-appropriate versions (for 4, 5 and 6-year-olds) form the basic learning material for focused listening activities, followed by commentary, Q&A, re-telling of student versions, graphic illustration of episodes in the correct order, etc. The reason why an hour per week devoted to the comprehension of and interaction with the traditional narrative genre is higher-order and literacy-related is that this kind of language ability goes beyond highly context-embedded, face-to-face, conversation that lacks the text/discourse structure of this kind of narrative genre. It requires the cognitively demanding processing of text (via listening, a preparation for the processing of text via reading). Many children miss the chance to develop higher-order comprehension, while others receive it from their family before elementary school.

Crucially, the learning of text/discourse patterns via one language (e.g. Thái) forms knowledge structures that are available for application to academic tasks via another language (e.g. Vietnamese), and vice versa. Stored in long-term memory, text/discourse processing abilities maintain a kind of autonomy, or independence, from strictly linguistic competence, reason for which they can be applied to learning tasks in the manner described. The relevant learning processes have been the subject of research, and well understood, for many years (Cummins, 1991). Aside from the benefit to subsequent advanced literacy learning, the effect on any hypothetical decline in Thái language competence among a sub-sample in the present study (the 12 children out of the 47 who scored below near-native, referenced above) and similar cases, should be obvious. Previous research indicates that structured bilingual

interventions can mitigate the effects of language attrition, particularly when targeted at the early stages of education.

Parenthetically, the project's assessment battery contains a relevant example in the free narration subsection (mentioned above), not used in the current assessment for evaluating literacy-related ability, but simply as a redundant measure following the Q&A subsection to check for previous conversational listening comprehension. We cannot say with absolute confidence what the long-term result would be of a bilingual instruction capsule of this kind. It is proposed as a working hypothesis for ongoing fieldwork in the community.

7 Conclusion

In summarizing this interim report, we can return to the theme of competition and cooperation. In both language learning and language unlearning (attrition), both competition and cooperation unfold in bilingual contact situations. In the case of unlearning, focusing on situations of contact involving the Vietnamese language, there is the widely observed outcome of *attrition of L1 Vietnamese* among first- and second-generation immigrant bilingual speakers in all overseas communities. Taiwan is where the project examined this outcome in the contact with Chinese. Then, in the bilingual contact situation of Vietnamese language with Thái language, across communities near the border with Laos, the project was able to examine the possible outcome (still to be confirmed) of *attrition of L1 Thái*.

In each of these two contact situations (in Taiwan and in Vietnam), learning the minority language faces the competing influence of the majority national language. The national language potentially becomes dominant from the psycholinguistic point of view; and the evidence may be revealed on performance measures. Again, in the bilingual Thái-Vietnamese communities, this unlearning outcome (the psychological and linguistic outcome) still needs to be confirmed or disconfirmed. The majority language becomes dominant in other respects, topic for now that needs to be deferred.

In contrast, a second language learning dynamic of cooperation/coordination, comes onto the scene when initiatives of recovery and revitalization are undertaken. The analogy here is from the section on codeswitching and borrowing in which the speaker needs to *coordinate* the grammars from two languages that make contact in the same sentence.

In Taiwan, for example, the young adult children of immigrants who are now second language learners of Vietnamese are no longer in a situation of competition between two first languages, the mother-tongue and the school language. Vietnamese language and Chinese language no longer compete as they did during 3-year-old preschool. Learning or improving the Vietnamese grammar would very rarely, if ever, be at the expense of young adults' knowledge of Chinese.

In a similar way, a program, as described above (in the previous section), for the recovery and consolidation of Thái language development in a situation of already

mastered school Vietnamese, in the case of the bilingual first graders, would not present any competing interference. The bilingual instruction proposed for kindergarten and first grade would be of the kind that is termed in the second language learning literature as (in this case, strictly and unambiguously) “additive.” In the Thái community schools, children are immersed daily in Vietnamese language instruction, after having acquired Vietnamese from their parents and their preschool teachers, and are now learning how to read and write in the national script. For these first-grade learning objectives, there is no looking back. Under such conditions, stabilizing Thái language development involving a modest investment of time would never be at the expense of children’s advancing knowledge of Vietnamese language.

In comparison, the learning scenario for the adult heritage language students, for example in Taiwan, is somewhat more complicated. For a Vietnamese second language recovery project, typically, entry-level competence varies widely as well as rate of progress and ultimate attainment.

When thinking about linguistic and cognitive aspects of language learning, on the one hand, and applications for education and language policy on the other, it’s clear that there are many ways in which the two fields of research are related. At the same time, we can appreciate how the two are separate in many ways, how the findings of one do not automatically or easily lead to conclusions in the other. Future research can prioritize longitudinal studies to better understand the long-term effects of language contact in bilingual communities. Additionally, research on language use in daily interaction will be key to confirming observed changes in other domains of bilingual contact.

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